

4	Results and Evaluation	13
4.1	Measurement	13
4.2	The fitted law	13
4.3	Variance partitioning and the intrinsic-difficulty decomposition	14
4.4	Out-of-sample validation	15
4.5	Species hold-out (H1): novelty and the size confound	16
4.6	False positives / hallucination	18
4.7	Ablations and robustness	18
4.8	SAM3 familiarity proxy	21
4.9	Independent replication (MammAlps)	21
4.10	Independent replication (BURST)	23
4.11	Cross-dataset synthesis	24
5	Discussion	26
5.1	Interpretation	26
5.2	Relation to prior label-free evaluation	26
5.3	Reconciling the environment null with the background-bias literature	27
5.4	Why label-free distances do not yield a deployment estimator	28
5.5	Limitations and threats to validity	28
5.6	Ethical considerations	28
6	Conclusion	29
6.1	Summary of findings	29
6.2	Contributions	29
6.3	Future work	29
	Bibliography	30
A	Mathematical definitions	32
A.1	The promptable-tracking metric	32
A.2	Label-free distances	32
A.3	Model and statistics	33
B	Algorithms	34
C	Supplementary results	36

List of Figures

3.1	The measurement-and-modelling pipeline	7
3.2	The image-based distances in action	9
4.1	Coefficient forest plot	14
4.2	Out-of-sample predicted vs actual	16
4.3	The size confound	17

List of Tables

4.1	Zero-shot SAM3 on the SA-FARI test split — support-weighted mean over 346 scored cells (of 1447).	13
4.2	Standardised logit-GLM coefficients with <i>group-cluster-bootstrap</i> 95% CIs (resampling whole species / locations, so the interval respects pseudo-replication and the support weighting), for detection (pDetA) and association (pAssA). Every distance’s CI spans zero.	13
4.3	Variance partition for detection (pDetA): each distance’s unique share of R^2 (LMG/Shapley) and its VIF. The four distances together explain only $\approx 3\%$ of the variance, no factor dominates, and every $VIF \approx 1$ — the null is not masked by collinearity.	14
4.4	Nested size decomposition of the intrinsic-difficulty test (detection, 346 cells). Each entry is the out-of-sample MAE gain over a mean-predictor baseline, Δ [95% CI] (p), under leave-species-out and leave-location-out. The entire gain sits in the size covariate (log-area); low-light <i>alone</i> does not validate — the difficulty signals only pass the bar by riding on size.	15
4.5	Out-of-sample error: whole-group hold-out (leave-species-out / leave-location-out) vs a mean predictor. Δ is the MAE gain over baseline; its bracketed 95% CI and one-sided p come from a paired bootstrap resampling whole held-out groups. No hold-out’s gain is significant.	15
4.6	Zero-shot SAM3 on the pooled train+test set — support-weighted mean over 1025 scored cells (of 2126).	16
4.7	Standardised logit-GLM coefficients with <i>group-cluster-bootstrap</i> 95% CIs (resampling whole species / locations, so the interval respects pseudo-replication and the support weighting), for detection (pDetA) and association (pAssA).	17
4.8	Out-of-sample error: whole-group hold-out (leave-species-out / leave-location-out) vs a mean predictor. Δ is the MAE gain over baseline; its bracketed 95% CI and one-sided p come from a paired bootstrap resampling whole held-out groups. No hold-out’s gain is significant.	17
4.9	False positives on the 1486 hard negatives (113 species): the overall hallucination rate is 9.8%. More visually distinctive species hallucinate <i>less</i> — a real, size-independent correlate — but it does not validate out of sample (leave-species-out $p = 0.053$), so it is a correlate, not a predictor.	18
4.10	Factor ablation for detection (pDetA): McFadden pseudo- R^2 and the out-of-sample MAE gain over a mean baseline under leave-species-out (LSO) and leave-location-out (LLO). Dropping any single distance barely changes the fit or the (null) out-of-sample gain — no factor carries signal; only adding the animal-size covariate moves the score.	18

4.11	Design-robustness sweep (detection). Each row re-runs the primary four-distance model with one design choice swapped; entries are the out-of-sample MAE gain over a mean-predictor baseline, Δ [95% CI] (p), under leave-species-out and leave-location-out, with significance judged after Bonferroni ($m = 5$). The null holds throughout: no encoder, crop, prompt, or distributional distance makes the label-free distances beat the mean.	20
4.12	SAM3 familiarity proxy (T2.5, detection): does the separability of a species in SAM3’s <i>own</i> vision-encoder feature space predict pDetA ? Each metric is size-controlled and validated at the same leave-species-out bar as the distances; Δ MAE (p) is the out-of-sample gain over a mean predictor. None clears the Bonferroni threshold ($\alpha = 0.05/3 = 0.017$) on the leave-species-out (novelty) test on either dataset. The last columns (SA-FARI) are the cell-level correlations with the DINOv2 visual distance and animal size: all three metrics largely <i>re-encode</i> the visual distance ($r_{\text{vis}} = 0.63\text{--}0.85$). On the same 346 SA-FARI cells the before-running animal-size control validates out-of-sample, so this is a genuine null, not an underpowered one.	21
4.13	Zero-shot SAM3 on MammAlps — support-weighted mean over the 20 probe cells (MammAlps ships no separate reference split; all clips are probe). Scored with bbox-HOTA (<code>eval.prefer_bbox</code>): the ground truth is box-only, so mask-IoU is near-zero (dataset mask mAP ≈ 0.002) and box-IoU is the honest metric. The score is non-degenerate — SAM3 genuinely finds Alpine mammals zero-shot.	22
4.14	MammAlps independent replication — out-of-sample error of the pre-registered label-free distance model (taxonomic + visual + environment) under whole-group hold-out, against a mean predictor. Hold-out <i>camera</i> is leave-one-camera-out (the environment scheme); <i>species</i> is leave-one-species-out. Δ is the MAE gain over baseline; the bracketed 95% CI and one-sided p come from a paired bootstrap resampling whole held-out groups. Every interval spans zero on both targets and both schemes: the label-free distances do not predict transfer, directionally consistent with the SA-FARI null. $n = 20$ cells (5 species, 9 cameras); a single-cell fox fold and near-constant taxonomic distance leave the species scheme underpowered.	22
4.15	Zero-shot SAM3 on the BURST val animal subset — support-weighted mean over the 132 probe cells (41 species). Mask-native ground truth, scored with mask-HOTA (dataset mask mAP 0.49, bbox mAP 0.51). The score is non-degenerate and the association target is genuine ($\text{corr}(\text{pDetA}, \text{pAssA}) = 0.76$, 71/132 multi-object cells).	23
4.16	BURST independent replication — out-of-sample error under leakage-free leave-species-out cross-validation (41 species, 132 mask-native cells), against a mean predictor. Δ is the MAE gain over baseline for pDetA ; the bracketed 95% CI and one-sided p come from a paired bootstrap resampling whole held-out species. Every before-running distance is null (CI spans zero); not even the animal-size control reaches significance here, so BURST is a convergent null that cannot independently certify power for a small species-level effect. BURST has no shared locations, so leave-species-out is the only valid scheme.	24
4.17	What was tested, the numerical out-of-sample result, and on which dataset. Result is the leave-species-out gain in MAE over a mean predictor (Δ MAE, with one-sided bootstrap p) unless noted; positive and significant means the feature predicts transfer. The before-running label-free distances are null on all three datasets; the only before-running quantity that reaches significance is the animal-size confound, and only modestly on SA-FARI (which doubles as the positive control that keeps the null honest). “Opposite direction” means the association runs the reverse of what novelty predicts — more-novel animals are detected <i>better</i> , not worse — so it cannot support the hypothesis.	25

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Motivation

Promptable video trackers such as SAM 3 [5] segment and track any named animal in a video with no training on that species, and conservation teams now deploy them on new species and regions constantly. Yet no rule tells a practitioner, *before running the model*, whether its output is trustworthy for a given animal in a given place.

1.2 Problem statement and research question

This dissertation asks whether SAM 3’s zero-shot tracking accuracy on an unseen (species, place) can be *predicted in advance* from properties measurable without any label of the target, and which factors govern that transfer — separately for *finding* the animal and *following* it.

1.3 Hypotheses

H0 (null)

the label-free distances carry no predictive information about pDetA/pAssA — transfer is not distance-driven.

H1 (detection)

pDetA falls with species novelty (taxonomic + visual distance).

H2 (association)

pAssA falls with environment difficulty (scene, day/night/IR, clutter, camera motion).

Failing to reject H0 is itself an informative result — and, as Chapter 4 shows, it is what we find: neither a novelty distance nor a follow-up *intrinsic-difficulty* pivot predicts transfer beyond a trivial animal-size effect. Representational probing (does SAM 3 encode taxonomy?) remains the open branch for future work.

1.4 Contributions

To our knowledge this is the first study to *predict*, before the model is run and from label-free distances, the zero-shot transfer of a promptable video tracker — and the first to split that prediction into **detection** (pDetA) and **association** (pAssA). This distinguishes it from label-free performance prediction for classifiers, which estimates a single scalar from the model’s own outputs on the target [2, 9, 15], and from the very recent static-image detector/segmenter estimators [20, 23]; and from camera-trap shift studies, which measure but do not forecast per-site reliability [3, 4, 11]. Concretely we deliver: (i) a rigorous, out-of-sample *negative* result —

under a deliberately powerful test (whole-species and whole-location hold-out with group-cluster-bootstrap significance), label-free before-running distances do *not* predict SAM3’s transfer; (ii) the detection-versus-association decomposition, tested on two near-orthogonal splits — a constructed species hold-out (novelty) and the official location hold-out (environment); and (iii) a *hardened* account of *why* it fails: a follow-up intrinsic-difficulty pivot collapses to the same animal-size confound, so the only label-free property that predicts detection is object size — the very nuisance the analysis controls for — and that positive control confirms the test detects signal when it exists.

1.5 Dissertation outline

Chapter 2 reviews the related work; Chapter 3 describes the data, measurement, distance features, and modelling; Chapter 4 reports the results and out-of-sample validation; Chapter 5 discusses them; Chapter 6 concludes.

Chapter 2

Background and Related Work

This chapter places the dissertation among four bodies of work: promptable segmentation and tracking (the model we study), the tracking metric and its detection/association decomposition (how we score it), label-free prediction of out-of-distribution performance (the statistical idea we extend), and distribution shift in camera-trap vision (the application and the closest empirical neighbours). It closes by stating precisely the gap this work fills.

2.1 Promptable segmentation and tracking

The *Segment Anything* line moved segmentation from a fixed label set to an interactive, promptable formulation, and its successors extended prompting from points and boxes to *concepts*. SAM3 [5] is a promptable model that, given a short text prompt such as "impala", detects, segments, and tracks every matching instance across a video with no training on that category — a *zero-shot*, open-vocabulary detect–segment–track capability. It is exactly this capability that conservation teams now deploy on new species and regions, and it is the (frozen) model whose transfer we predict. SAM3 was released alongside SA-FARI [21], a large multi-animal camera-trap tracking dataset that we use as the substrate for our natural experiment (Section 2.6). We treat SAM3 strictly as a fixed black box: we never fine-tune it, and the only quantity we fit is a small regression *about* its behaviour.

2.2 The tracking metric and its decomposition

Higher Order Tracking Accuracy (HOTA) [13] evaluates multi-object tracking by combining, over a range of localisation thresholds, a *detection* term (**DetA**: were the right objects found?) and an *association* term (**AssA**: were identities kept consistent over time?). SA-FARI scores promptable tracking with a promptable variant, **pHOTA**, that decomposes identically into **pDetA** and **pAssA**. This decomposition is the intellectual core of the dissertation: rather than predict a single scalar, we ask whether *finding* and *following* an animal transfer for *different reasons* — the former with how novel the animal is, the latter with how difficult the scene is — and we therefore model the two components separately throughout.

2.3 Predictable out-of-distribution generalisation

A now-mature literature shows that a model’s performance under distribution shift can be anticipated *without* target labels. Miller et al. [15] observe that out-of-distribution (OOD) accuracy is strongly linearly correlated with in-distribution accuracy across many models and shifts, and Baek et al. [2] show that the *agreement* between a pair of models tracks OOD accuracy closely enough to estimate it from unlabelled data alone. A parallel strand estimates accuracy from a